

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Use and Refuse

"I want to cut a billion tonnes of carbon dioxide from the air each year"

VIDYUT MOHAN, 30

Co-founder & CEO, Takachar **Delhi**

Delhi-based entrepreneur Vidyut Mohan's start-up Takachar (literally, money from carbon) aims to provide affordable machines for farmers to convert their agri-waste into cash. One of the five winners of the Earthshot Prize, 2021, he has pilot projects in Haryana and Africa operate on a simple principle. Existing machines that process farm waste are large, centrally located and need huge logistics to transport crop waste. Mohan's start-up plans to hook up these compact machines on to tractors, making them portable and affordable, and give farmers a new revenue stream. The idea germinated from his master's thesis at the Delft University of Technology in the Netherlands. There was, he discovered, little interest in using crop and forest residues as a source of renewable energy as compared to wind and solar power. Not tackled at their source, this crop waste could turn into a health hazard like what happened on November 5 this year when the share of stubble burning in Delhi's polluted air peaked at an alarming 48 per cent of PM 2.5 particulate matter. He's working with a Bengaluru-based firm to mass produce the prototypes, which can convert rice straw, rice husk and even coconut shells into fuel and fertiliser. ■

–Sandeep Unnithan

A DIFFERENT BEAT Mohan is an accomplished tabla player